

GETTING OUT THE YOUTH VOTE:
FINDINGS FROM A NATURAL EXPERIMENT IN
THE RIO GRANDE VALLEY

by

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by

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This study assesses efforts made by a non-partisan non-profit organization, the Advocacy Alliance Center of Texas (AACT), to engage South Texas youth in the democratic political process. Specifically, the question it asks and tries to answer is whether activities associated with a Get Out The Vote (GOTV) campaign aimed at 18/19 year-old high school seniors can raise their voter turnout rate above what it might otherwise be without intervention. The research adopts a quasi-experimental design that analyzes data on 4435 students produced from a natural non-randomized experiment where some schools and students did and other schools and students did not participate in campaign activities leading up to the Primary and General elections of 2012. Findings indicate that "treatments" targeting high school seniors can be effective in raising voter turnout in this population, sometimes by several multiples, more so for

General than for Primary elections. Treatment effects vary, however. A one-day, large-scale regional youth "Summit," a celebration integrating voter registration, educational presentations and entertainment seemed to have greater effect on turnout than in-school registration and presentations. How much of the gain stems from program effect and how much from self-selection is uncertain, however.

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CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

Every vote seemed to count as Candidate Mitt Romney and incumbent President Barack Obama watched poll numbers trickle in during the November 2012 election. Leading up to Election Day the candidates and their staff worked hard to identify particular groups – by location, ethnicity, gender, age, etc. – that might help push the candidate to victory. The need for disaggregating the electorate was clear. Given that every vote counted in a tight race, campaign activities had to be designed in ways that could maximize participation by every group.

Unfortunately, these kinds of efforts have historically borne little fruit in South Texas – a generally poor, predominantly Hispanic region - where voter registration and turnout rates have remained well below the state average for a very long time. This is unfortunate because low participation at the ballot box has for a very long time underwritten political powerlessness and corresponding inability to influence public policy in ways that might help to more quickly reduce poverty in the region. Without having to respond to voter pressure for favorable policy changes, decision makers at county, state and Federal levels have been able to get by with what sometimes appears to be little more than lip service about the need to address poverty and improve basic public services for low income residents. With more than 70% of the region's population, and more than 90% of the poverty population Hispanic, the issue in South Texas is colored to an

important (but not exclusive) extent by an ethnic dimension. That is, the matters at hand also fall under the general rubric of Hispanic poverty, powerlessness and methods to address these.

The same situation presents itself in many other places where Hispanics, by their numbers, are significant shares of the population. There however, as well as in South Texas, change seems afoot as expanding Hispanic communities increasingly recognize the potential that their numbers represent for expanding their power and influence on policy at all levels. As researcher Baltazar Arispe points out, the Rio Grande Valley is not simply “American on one side and Mexican on the other” but rather it is a third country with its own identity (Baltazar Arispe y Acevedo 2009).

The Pew Hispanic Center (2012), for instance, reports that the population of eligible Latino voters in the United States rose from 7.7 million in 1988 to 23.7 million in 2012, an increase of 34%. In parallel, the number of actual voters rose from 3.7 million in 1998 to 12.5 million in 2012, a 30% rise. So the prospect of important shifts in power and political influence, already underway in several parts of the country, is becoming ever clearer. A relevant question in this regard is: When will the process reach maturity... reach the point where political influence becomes commensurate with Hispanic shares of local, state and national populations?

A sense of the speed of movement is suggested in a recent study by the Pew Hispanic Center (2012). The study notes that the population of eligible Latino voters rose from 7.7 million in 1988 to 23.7 million in 2012, an increase of about 34%, and the number of actual voters rose from 3.7 million in 1998 to 12.5 million in 2012, an increase of about 30%. The study adds that while the Hispanic population of the United States is approximately 17%, it makes up only 10%

of voters. But because the Latino median age is younger than that of Anglos (24 versus 42), the Hispanic share of the age-eligible electorate will rise markedly in coming years.

The political import of this demographic shift, however, will depend on growth in the share of these age-eligible who actually vote. This growth is less predictable, in part because two factors weigh heavily on political participation: poverty and associated powerlessness that in combination underpin broad-ranging disengagement from the economic, social or political systems in the milieus of Hispanic communities.

In 1982, for example, the Hispanic poverty rate was 30%, double the national average of 15% (U.S. Bureau of the Census, 1988, 13).¹ Five years later, the respective figures were 27% and 14% (U.S. Bureau of the Census, 1988, 13).² Coming closer to the present, the estimated Hispanic poverty rate dropped to 23% between 2007 and 2011, and the national rate to 14%. Clearly, there has been a reduction in the poverty rate, but the position of Hispanics relative to other groups has not budged by much (Macartney, Bishaw, and Fontenot, 2013: 13).³

At the same time, this relative poverty has helped to sustain relative powerlessness and the associated inability to influence policy in directions that might help to reduce poverty more quickly (Jang, 2009). In Texas, one clear manifestation of powerlessness is the relatively small share of Federal, State and local officials who are Hispanic, 7% in 2003, perhaps 10% today.⁴

¹ <http://www2.census.gov/prod2/popscan/p60-160.pdf>, page 13 accessed 7/5/2013

² *ibid*

³ <http://www.census.gov/prod/2013pubs/acsbr11-17.pdf>, pg. 13 accessed 7/5/2013

⁴ http://www.laits.utexas.edu/txp_media/html/vce/features/0503_04/latinos.html

Another manifestation, implied above, is limited voter registration and low and irregular turnout by those who are registered.

This is not to say that Hispanic communities are politically passive or indifferent. When directly or indirectly threatened, when they sense that they have something important to lose, they can and do seem to mobilize strongly. Anti-immigrant sentiment in California during the 1990s, for example, led to a big increase in Hispanic voter registration and turnout, notably of younger people (Jang, 2009). This kind of threat, however, is irregular. Although periodic responses to threats demonstrate the capacity of Hispanic communities to mobilize for communal political action, such threats are short-lived, as are the responses. Absent threat, communities revert to relative disengagement. There is nothing in the milieu to propel further large or sustained action. The notion of organizing and voting for change in the general order of things so that communities can routinely help to shape policies that serve their interests in a positive way, not just reaction to threats, is apparently not yet as deeply engrained in Hispanic communities as in others (Jang, 2009). If it is to become more deeply engrained, then it is important to understand why they do or do not vote.

WHY HISPANICS VOTE

As noted for California, and as is the case with most groups, Hispanics can be inspired to act on issues that appear as threats. The more recent anti-immigration reform movement organized by Hispanic organizations across the country demonstrates how consciousness-raising about a

prospective threat can provoke people on a grand scale. The danger of losing something important is a big motivator of political action, most notably through noisy demonstrations, marches and the like. But participation via the ballot box is much rarer, in large measure because Hispanics do not register to vote in significant numbers, and have not done for a long time.

For this reason, there is a long tradition of organizational effort to register Hispanic voters and, after registration, to get them to actually vote. A relatively recent instance is creation in 1976 of the National Association of Latino Elected Democrats, and its transformation in 1981 into the non-partisan National Association of Latino Elected and Appointed Officials, or NALEO (Barreto, 2007). This organization led efforts to highlight and promote the need for more Hispanic elected officials at all levels, and sought to achieve this through registration drives, Get-Out-The-Vote (GOTV) campaigns and recruitment of Hispanics to run for public office (Barreto, 2007). NALEO set the foundation for noteworthy increases of Hispanics in office. During 1996-2011, for instance, Hispanic representation in government expanded by more than 50%, from about 3,745 to 5,850 (2011 Directory of Latino Elected Officials, 2013). At the same time, the number of states with political representation by Hispanics grew from 34 to 43, with Texas, Arizona, New Mexico and California having the highest number of such elected officials (2011 Directory of Latino Elected Officials, 2013). Noteworthy also given the matriarchal character of Hispanic households, the number of female Hispanics in office more than doubled. They now comprise 32% of all Hispanic elected officials (2011 Directory of Latino Elected Officials, 2013).

These various officials, in large measure, owe their positions to strong support from large Hispanic constituencies. Although having Hispanic candidates on ballots does drive up voter participation for specific elections, longer term effects on political participation remain uncertain. A study of voter turnout for the 2001 Los Angeles Mayor's race, for instance, suggests that, "...given the right set of circumstances, Latinos are more likely to turn out at rates higher than those of non-Latinos, and to support co-ethnic candidates" (Barreto, Villarreal and Woods 2005). In this instance a Hispanic, Antonio Villariagosa, won a surprise spot in the general election for Los Angeles mayor in a primary runoff, but then lost the race. Nonetheless, his presence boosted turnout and garnered an estimated 80% of all Hispanic votes (Barreto, Villarreal and Woods, 2005). So while Hispanics on a ballot can increase turnout, this is a very narrow base for political engagement. Needed is a broader range of issues on the table and formed habits that can encourage Hispanics to turn out election cycle after cycle.

To cultivate interest in wider issues and promote the habit of voting, many grassroots organizations have focused on educating and mobilizing younger voters. This approach seems based on a bit of research suggesting that it takes two or three generations for ethnic groups to assimilate and then begin to think about working towards changing political landscapes. Lisa Martinez points to research indicating that second generations of Americans will often establish "reactive formations" around ethnic identity as a backlash against institutional discrimination suffered by their parents or the preceding generation (Martinez, 2004). This seems consistent with the experiences of immigration reform, which became a rallying cause for many Hispanics in the 1990s and then widened to include many more Hispanics in the early 2000s.

But the evidence does not always support this notion of generational increase in participation. Martinez also reports that Hispanics who have assimilated into American culture, third-generation and beyond, tend to vote at lower rates than the first or second generation (Martinez, 2004). Early generation Hispanics who had to fight and earn their right to vote, most often by becoming citizens, had clear reason to combat institutional racism and discriminatory policies through the ballot box. Generations that followed and benefitted from prior actions do not have the same incentive. So although one perspective suggests that third and fourth generations should have built-in desires to participate in the political process, another perspective is that the desire is not all that strong and, as a result, that these later generations require strong incentive to do so. The need for strong incentive is certainly there.

For example, revisiting the Los Angeles mayoralty race in 2001, Hispanics comprised 47% of the Los Angeles population at that time (Barreto, Villarreal and Woods, 2005). Yet they constituted only 22% of the electorate. A difference explained by high numbers of undocumented residents and by demographics....families with large numbers of young children below voting age (Barreto, Villarreal and Woods, 2005). But even if Hispanics have a disproportionately lower share of the electorate than their share of population, they can weigh in heavily in politics. In the 2001 race they had higher turnout (40%) than any other group (Barreto, Villarreal and Woods, 2005). In contrast, in the 1997 mayoral election when two white candidates vied for office and Hispanics accounted for just 14% of voters, their share of the electorate was 16% (Barreto, Villarreal and Woods , 2005).

Of note here is that the 2001 race contained racial overtones. The campaign of the white candidate, James Hahn, accused Villaraigosa of supporting crime (Barreto, Villarreal and Woods, 2005). This accusation cost Villaraigosa many white votes, but at the same time it underwrote a groundswell of Hispanic support for the Villaraigosa campaign (Barreto, Villarreal and Woods, 2005). Indeed, NALEO joined the fray to help register voters in an effort to elect Los Angeles' first Hispanic mayor (Barreto, Villarreal and Woods, 2005). The racial tone of the Hahn campaign may have just been a side issue that did not influence voters concerned by other pressing matters, but it is hard to dismiss the sense that race was a factor in driving Hispanic voter turnout.

VOTER TURNOUT

So it seems evident that ethnicity, when it emerges as part of political discourse during elections, can raise voter turnout, at least in some instances. But, just as clear, it is not productive to rely only on that as a foundation upon which to raise turnout. The crucial question for campaigns, Hispanic or other, is how to effectively raise voter turnout for candidates on a consistent, sustained basis without recourse to playing the "ethnic" or "race" card. Important here is the ability of campaign organizers and parties to turn out voters in non-federal election years when turnout is very low across the board and, in other years, to prevent voting drop offs on down ballot races that typically have greatest local impact.⁵ And especially important, because they represent a large and rapidly-growing share of the American and Hispanic population and

⁵ Down ballot races are those where non-Presidential candidates are listed below Presidential nominees on the ballot and where, as a result, degree of nominee popularity affects prospects for other contenders from the same political party.

electorate, are campaigns that focus on the youth vote of third, fourth, fifth generations that today, typically produce inconsistent and generally very low turnout.

This is hard to do, although the task has been eased a bit for Federal elections by the Help America Vote Act (HAVA), signed into law in 2002 (Tokaji and Gronke, 2013). HAVA made voting easier and more reliable by replacing old tabulation methods (e.g., lever machines) with new. But there is no evidence to indicate whether provisional balloting, a measure that can help more transient people have their votes count, or record keeping, has actually improved (Tokaji and Gronke, 2013). In any event, HAVA is not relevant for most elections... which are run at the state and local level and follow own sets of laws and standards (Tokaji and Gronke, 2013).

At these levels there have been some interesting tests of alternative ways to increase voter turnout, by changing the ways in which elections are carried out and/or by experimenting with different approaches to mobilizing voters. Oregon's shift to voting exclusively by mail, which is basically absentee voting for everyone, is a noteworthy example of changing methods of election. Voter turnout is expected to rise because this method eliminates what some call the "cumbersome" nature of voting at polling stations, it allows voters to act on their own timetable and with relative ease. Polling costs fall because of not having to acquire voting machines, polling place staff and space on Election Day (Gronke and Miller, 2012) report that introduction of the vote by mail format yielded an estimated turnout increase of 2% to 4% across elections, with largest increases, up to 11%, seen in special elections and down-ballot races. Interestingly, (Arceneaux, Kousser and Mullin, 2012) suggest that part of this rise stems from that fact that the

mailed ballot reminds recipients that an election is actually under way, not that it will take place at some future date.

Perhaps more important, according to Arceneaux, Kousser and Mullin (2012) is that in vote by mail elections the personal significance of voting is not as high and the social stigma that comes with not voting is low. Evidence for this is that when a group of voters received a GOTV mailer stating that their voting or non-voting would be reported to neighbors, there was an 8% increase in turn out. For a matched comparison group that received a mailer indicating only that voting was their civic duty, turnout rose by 2% (Arceneaux, Kousser and Mullin, 2012). It would seem that, on the margin, guilt is a bigger driver of turnout in mail elections than civic pride.⁶

As an aside, the supposed downside of the vote by mail method, as Yasinsac (2012) points out, is that it is vulnerable to fraud. This may or may not remain a problem if/when voting moves to the Internet in a big way, such as in the 2004 Michigan Democratic Primary election where twice as many people voted by Internet rather than mail (Prevost and Schaffner, 2008).

But legislative change such as HAVA or Oregon's shift to the vote-by-mail election method raises turnout mainly by lowering barriers that confront those already somewhat predisposed to vote. It does not have as much effect on people who are largely indifferent to or oblivious of voting, such as a great many young people. Since these individuals represent a large share of the electorate, there has been considerable testing of alternative methods to increase their turnout via Get Out The Vote (GOTV) campaigns. At the same time, because these methods can be costly

⁶ The supposed downside of the vote by mail method, as Yasinsac (2012, 58) points out, is that it is vulnerable to fraud. This may or may not remain a problem if/when voting shifts to the Internet, such as in the 2004 Michigan Democratic Primary election where twice as many people voted by Internet relative to mail (Prevost and Schaffner 2008, 519).

and quickly exhaust campaign budgets, there has also been testing of cost-effectiveness, e.g., focusing campaign efforts in "vote dense" areas in order to increase chances of getting the highest voter bang for every campaign buck.

Set against this background, the research project described in this dissertation is an examination of the effectiveness of one such GOTV test implemented by a non-partisan, non-profit organization, the Advocacy Alliance Center of Texas (AACT), in three counties of South Texas. The test is of a multi-pronged GOTV program to register mostly (but not exclusively) Hispanic high school seniors, and to encourage them to vote in the Primary and General elections of 2012. Because several high schools declined to participate in the campaign, this presented an opportunity to test effectiveness with data from a "natural" field experiment.

In what follows, Chapter 2 presents and discusses the evolution of various GOTV campaigns, and experimental and other assessments that have tried to measure their effectiveness. Chapter 3 then describes the origin and evolution of the AACT, and the activities it implemented in South Texas to register and encourage high school seniors to vote in the 2012 elections. Chapter 4, methodology, assesses the extent to which the AACT succeeded in raising voter turnout relative to what it might have been in the absence of those activities. Finally, Chapter 5 presents my conclusions and briefly discusses implications of my findings for the research community and for political practice.

CHAPTER 2

THE EVOLUTION OF GOTV

For those engaged in them, GOTV campaigns are works of dynamic art filled with ritual, spreadsheets and a bucketful of techniques to woo voters. At their common core is an array of often-contradictory theories- some prefer to just call them assumptions or opinions- that explain voting behavior and that serve as basic inputs to campaign design. These theories are varied. Some scholars suggest that voting from the perspective of self-interest is an irrational act while others claim that it is perfectly rational. The rational calculus, as set out by Downs (Downs, 1957) notes that voting is costly, and so a decision to do it, given an assumption that a single vote will make little difference, may seem irrational because of these costs. However, there might be compensating intangible benefits that are independent of outcome, such as supporting democracy when an individual values this, the welfare of others, or other community or societal concerns (Fowler and Kam, 2007). Since valuation of intangible benefits vary from person to person, as (Riker and Ordeshook, 1968) argue, one can infer that it is reasonable for those who vote to do so and equally reasonable for those who do not vote to refrain from doing so. The basic implication here is that GOTV campaigns must act in ways that raise the value of benefits perceived by prospective voters above the value of costs.

But well before identifying individuals and encouraging them to go to the polls, there is the fundamental matter of registering them as voters, a process that, depending on the level and

complexity of demands imposed by state law, can affect willingness to vote (Tischenko, 2010). That is, the way in which a person registers may affect willingness to turn out. Process can make a big difference. Burden and Neiheisel (2013) suggest, for instance, that if states adopt easier registration policies, then turnout could rise by anywhere from 8% to 14%. The Report of the Commission on Youth Voting and Civic Knowledge (2013) concurs that making registration easier for the youth increases their voter turnout. In addition, the report suggested that methods such as same day voting and mobile updating would encourage more of them to participate.

Although slow to change, and sometimes pushed back a few steps, the voter registration process has become progressively easier in recent times. The process was given an important boost when Congress passed National Voter Registration Act of 1993, often dubbed “motor-voter” registration because registration piggy-backed onto driver license applications (Crocker, 2013). A further boost came from the Help America Vote Act of 2002, which ensured states kept electronic records of voter registration and offered electronic voter registration (Coleman and Fischer, 2011).

However, under any registration and voter identification regime, the critical challenge for GOTV campaigns is to devise methods and messages that are effective in convincing registered voters to actually vote. Efforts to meet this challenge have in recent times benefitted from considerable empirical research on what works and does not work to raise turnout, particularly among youth between 18 and 24 years of age. Methods covered by this research include television advertisements, door to door canvassing, phone banking, direct mail, text messaging and message transmission through the internet and various social media.

Of particular interest are studies that have compared outcomes between voter groups subject to one or another "turnout treatment" - e.g., television advertisements, door to door canvassing, phone banking, direct mail, text messaging and message transmission through the internet and various social media- and groups that are not subject to the treatments. Main evaluation research designs adopted for this purpose are random assignment experiments in laboratory settings and field settings (i.e., during actual turnout campaigns), and "natural" experiments that emerge from the ways in which some campaigns are designed and implemented. These have produced interesting and useful findings about effectiveness of the television and radio advertisements, door to door canvassing, phone banking and direct mail campaigns via the internet and various social media

One important research finding is that personal contact can often make a big difference in willingness to vote and, therefore, that canvassing can be an effective way to mobilize people to the polls (Gerber and Green 2000; Green and Nickerson 2003; Michelson 2003; Nickerson 2006; Abrajano and Panagopoulos 2011). Door to door contact, at once the most effective and most expensive action due to its labor intensity, can increase voter turnout by as much as 6% (Gerber and Green 1999; Nickerson, Riedrichs and King ,2006). So depending on the value that one ascribes to each additional vote, the door to door approach can be the most or the least efficient method of a GOTV effort. Useful to note here is that effectiveness of canvassing can be raised or lowered substantially by small and subtle details such as tone of voice when delivering messages (Arceneaux and Nickerson, 2010). This may partly explain why canvassing studies that include effects on youth (18-24) often show contradictory findings- some cases are positive while others have no effect.

Television and radio advertisements, though not strictly speaking GOTV methods, can also have important effects. Contrary to claims made repeatedly over the years, rigorous studies have found that exposure to these ads in presidential elections can boost turnout by 10% or more (Freedman, Franz and Goldstein, 2004). This is particularly the case among those not intending to vote, such as a great many youth (Hillygus, 2005). Hispanic radio ads in 2006, for instance, were found to be responsible for a 5% turnout increase in Congressional races (Panagopoulos and Green, 2011), while media markets with Spanish language news have seen increases of 4% or so (Oberholzer-Gee and Woldfogel, 2009).

Then there is the telephone, used for both automated/robocalls and real-person calls. Robocalls playing prerecorded messages have been found to be quick in contacting individuals, but fairly ineffective in raising voter turnout- even when messages are voiced by political or cultural celebrities (Shaw, Green, Gimple and Gerber, 2012). Real-person phone calls by volunteers or paid canvassers, even if these volunteers and canvassers speak in Spanish and claim Hispanic culture, have been shown to be equally ineffective across multiple years, races and levels of contested office (Gerber and Green, 2005).

Of course, variations in turnout associated with different GOTV methods also reflect variations in messaging adopted by each method. For example, Ha and Karlan (2009), found that three different GOTV phone call messages produced three different turnout results... the best being associated with the most interactive message.

Research done by the Pew Internet and American Life Project stated that 18% of voters thought e-mail and online materials made them more likely to vote (Nickerson, 2007). Yet more

in depth research shows that e-mail fails to increase registration or turnout at a significant rate among voters (Nickerson, 2007). It could be suggested that if e-mail fails to work on those who are already disposed to vote, that it would be highly unlikely that it would work to increase turnout among younger or unregistered voters. This is not to say that e-mail is not an efficient way to stay in touch with younger voters to maintain a relationship with them, but it does not appear to affect actions by the message recipient.

Text messaging, although a new technique, has sparked interest in many campaigns looking to have a high impact with a low budget, especially those targeting youth. In order to test the effectiveness of this tactic Allison Dale and Aaron Strauss (2007) opted to evaluate a nationwide field experiment that would result in analyzing whether or not texting is a viable tool to use to mobilize the youth. The results of the research were conclusive in determining that by texting a person was statistically more likely to vote (Dale and Strauss, 2007). Half of all the participants in the text study were 18 years of age and for many this was their first time casting their vote. The findings of the research concluded that using text message as the mobilizing method meant a person would be 4.2% more likely to vote than if they had not received a reminder. Furthermore, they point out that this type of mobile outreach cost considerably less than traditional outreach methods such as canvassing. Participants who received text messages of varying substance, ranging from a reminder to vote to detailed poll location information, were receptive to the text and many thought that the text helped to remind them to vote (Dale and Strauss, 2007). Interestingly enough, and perhaps due to their often mobile lifestyle, there was a high rate of positive reaction among Hispanics (Dale and Strauss, 2007).

A study done by Richard Matland and Gregg Murray done on the efficacy of the Get Out The Vote (GOTV) campaign discovered that personal face-to-face or phone contact increased voter turnout. However, “robo calls” and generalized emails had little to no effect on voter turnout. They determined, “... the more personal the contact, the more effective the method.” (Murray, 2012) This was especially true when it came to Latino voters. Matland and Murray point out that personal and non-partisan messages to Latino voters about the importance of voting increased the percentage of voters more than mailed flyers or postcards, billboards or other impersonal forms of campaigning (Murray, 2012).

In regard specifically to Hispanics, the literature suggests that having lower turnout than most other groups does not affect response to GOTV campaigns. Shaw and de la Garza (2000) point out that Hispanics react similarly to non-Hispanics when voting in their own self-interest. What matters is the quality of mobilization directed at the Hispanic population (Goldstein and Ridout, 2002). On this score there is some disagreement on the meaning of quality. Some research has shown that Spanish language GOTV efforts drive turnout more than English efforts, though language matters less than the mere fact of direct contact (Abrajano and Panagopoulos, 2011).

The upshot of the foregoing review is that beyond indicating that door to door canvassing works reasonably well, there is not much consistency in findings. So the challenge of finding means to increase Hispanic voter turnout in general and of youth in particular remains. Further, looming over this discussion of ways to increase voter turnout is the matter of basic interest in voting at all. A 2003 study by the Center for Information and Research on Civic Learning and Engagement found that 53% of Hispanic youth felt voting wasn't important and only 25%

viewed voting as a right, an attitude attributed (as 58% of respondents reported) to the fact that they talked little or not at all about politics with parents (Levine and Lopez, 2002).

So the basic challenge, unchanged for a long time, is first to cultivate interest in voting among Hispanic and other youth and, once that is done, to get them to vote. Research that focuses specifically on this dual agenda may exist in the literature, but I have not yet discovered such materials. Published research that focuses specifically on the agenda as it might apply in the Rio Grande Valley is even less likely to be identified soon. And except for Dale and Strauss (2007), half of whose sample of first time voters were 18 years old, there is little other research available to indicate which methods may be effective for youth at that age.

Certainly, the approaches discussed above may be as effective (or ineffective) for 18/19 year olds in high school as those directed generally at prospective voters 18 to 24 years of age, many of most of whom are college students in the experimental studies. But there is a sense that there may be need for additional approaches to target high school seniors. Some such approaches, as yet untested for effect, include the Rock the Vote initiative. In 2004, rapper and hip-hop icon P. Diddy as well as several other Hollywood figures wore t-shirts that read- Vote or Die. This GOTV campaign was targeted at the 18-24 population, and hosted music concerts along with voter registration drives to encourage and motivate the youth. In addition, Rock the Vote provided free downloads of their materials for the teachers to share with their students- tracking turnout however was not reported.

Another initiative targeting youth was VotoLatino, which included giveaways of materials such as iPod music cards, and incentives to engage youth. Like Rock the Vote, VotoLatino was

co-founded by Rosario Dawson a Hollywood actress committed to engage Latino youth. It hosts yearly summits for young leaders from around the country, encouraging them to participate and learn techniques to engage the community. VotoLatino, although non-partisan, does focus on key issues, such as immigration, healthcare and legislation that specifically affect Latinos as means, among other things, to convince people to register and vote on these issues.

The 2012 election seemed to be a timely moment to test these kinds to youth-centric approaches. By then, the Report of the Commission on Youth and Civic Knowledge (2013) was in the process of preparing results of a comprehensive study of collaborations and innovations for youth engagement. Findings and recommendations in this report confirmed that there was scope for more specific youth approaches. For example, it noted that youth from disadvantaged backgrounds are less likely to be informed and to vote (2013). In addition, collaborations within communities were essential for successful civic engagement programs for youth.

Against this backdrop, the effort aimed directly at this youth group by the Advocacy Alliance Center of Texas (AACT) in the Rio Grande Valley during 2011-2013, described in the next chapter, is timely. Among other virtues, it is a way to assess effects of some of the novel approaches mentioned in the research and practitioner literatures with respect to youth. It provides an opportunity- in the form of data from a natural, non-randomized field experiment- to evaluate effectiveness of an approach to mobilizing youth to vote as they cross the threshold from being ineligible to being eligible to vote, i.e. while in their senior year in high school.

CHAPTER 3

THE AACT INTERVENTION

The 2008 presidential election produced record-setting voter turnout across the country, for example, reaching 70% to 80% of eligible voters in several parts of Texas. In South Texas, however, record setting meant a 40% turnout for the general population, lower for Hispanics.

These low rates troubled regional and local leaders in the public and private sectors who believed that the ballot box was the only way through which to express and communicate concerns and priorities of the Rio Grande Valley population, be they Hispanic or other, to decision making levels of the state and nation.

This concern was especially acute because several attempts by outside organizations and campaigns to increase voter turnout over the previous decade had made little headway in engaging the population to vote consistently in elections. Outside organizations were not successful because their 2 month band-aid approach did nothing to cultivate a sustainable civic engagement program nor did it provide the community with a credible and stable message. If South Texas was to move forward rather than spin wheels, the leaders reasoned that there was a need to try a home grown approach using local talent and initiative to educate, engage and empower their community year round. There being no obvious candidate organization available to husband this kind of effort, the leaders decided to create one. That is how AACT came to be.

The funder and visionary behind the formation of the proposed organization was Mr. Alonzo Cantu, a successful businessman whose parents immigrated from Mexico and in early days worked as migrant workers until they established a construction business. Mr. Cantu is often credited as the driving force behind transformation of the business and political landscape of South Texas. As a banker, developer, philanthropist and community organizer, he has exemplified the highest standard of community leadership.

With his backing, I was hired in 2011 to serve as a political management consultant under a 3-year contract, and I was charged to help create a non-partisan non-profit organization to raise voter turnout in South Texas. My political campaign experience and my prior work for Congressman Ruben Hinojosa of South Texas qualified me to understand something about the challenge ahead. Raising turnout demanded that educational efforts be successful in transforming the ways in which most residents viewed civic engagement.

AACT ORIGINS

First organizational meetings focused on what the new non-profit entity would do. It was important to incorporate community buy in; in fact, this became instrumental in formation of the entity. That is, the proposed organization would not duplicate existing operations. Rather, it would work to enhance and expand efforts already in place. The message to the community was that the organization was a grass roots effort destined to remain in the community for the long haul. It would collaborate with all relevant organizations to create a broad based GOTV effort with deep community roots. To set the appropriate non-partisan tenor, both the Democratic and Republican Party Chairs volunteered to serve as members of the organization's board. They

along with the other board members agreed that the overarching goal would be to use an umbrella strategy where in the organization would encompass a cross section of community, health, business, education and non-profit sectors in a coherent mechanism to promote voter education, engagement and higher voter turnout.

Also discussed was the crucial fact that AACT could not focus only on Hispanic voter turnout. AACT represented the entire region, and so should not focus entirely on just one segment of the population. This led to the decision for AACT to not take any position regarding political issues or candidates. The organization would just serve as an information dissemination hub, and would provide all-inclusive material regarding the importance of voter turnout. That being said, AACT would educate the public regarding the benefits of receiving state and national funding through representations.

NAMING TO ENGAGE

First impressions are everything and selecting a name for the organization proved more difficult than anticipated. The acronym had to be easy to remember, catchy perhaps, but at the same time suggest inclusivity, a united community effort and underscore a Texas orientation. After months of trial and error, I presented the board with Advocacy Alliance Center of Texas (AACT). It was not well received until the board keyed in on the acronym...suggesting that the organization wanted voters in South Texas to take ACTION. To make a difference, they needed to AACT (See APPENDIX A). It was also helpful that the Spanish translation of the name worked well, during the name presentation the Spanish media and radio had no problem with the translation and in fact we received positive feedback.

That done, the next step was to create a branding and logo with designer help, something shield-like and youthful in the tradition of Captain America, using red and blue to represent both political parties. Trial and error led to the final product designed by Rodrigo Rodriguez of Rio Bravo Pictures a founding board member. Since the formation the logo design has received awards and worked wonders for branding.

Next was creation of a short PowerPoint presentation to launch and introduce the organization to the community and media, one that could resonate with the public and serve as catalyst for Public Service Announcements. The thematic message adopted was simple but impactful: "In Texas 6 out of 10 people vote, but in the Valley only 2 out of 10 people vote." This statistic, combined with some facts about chronic underfunding of public services, proved highly effective in galvanizing interest. The Power Point in many ways opened the doors for AACT to form sustainable community collaborations. There were over 100 presentations delivered, and similar to the method of canvassing, the face to face delivery helped to form a bond with our new partners.

In October 2011 AACT officially requested 501(c)(3) certification status. Following the certification AACT would begin to implement their strategic outreach plan that consisted of various GOTV methods. By working and collaborating with organization at the regional, state and national level AACT was able to participate in the dialogue where the community's needs were explained. It was clear that in addition to the traditional methods of outreach such as canvassing and phone banking, something else had to be done.

IMPORTANCE OF AACT BOARD

The importance of the board in formation and execution of the AACT program cannot be overstated. Members played crucial roles in building credibility within the community and around the state, thereby opening doors that might otherwise have remained shut. Each board member was responsible for focusing on a specific target audience and adopting a specific strategy to succeed with it. For example, two members affiliated with regional universities assured that AACT was welcomed on campus, and facilitated student access and participation. Members connected to the financial sector helped AACT to secure funding and bring banks onboard. Relationships with municipalities assured important in-kind contributions, such as convention center space and transportation waivers for high schools. These kinds of community influence through board member initiative were crucial to success.

The strategy used behind the “center of influence” model was championed by Alonzo Cantu and was used to leverage influence during the election that would translate into engagement and participation. Each partner would be provided with a report that consisted of a breakdown of their voter turnout. It was clear early on that accountability would be the key to push an organizations commitment to the cause. This strategy worked with our participating partners and in many instances their voter turnout rate was double if not triple the turnout rate of the county.

GOALS

As noted, the basic goal from the outset was to increase voter turnout, starting with a lofty (and in the event unrealistic) target of raising it to 65%, about 5 percentage points higher than the state average in recent years, and 25 points higher than the region's best historical turnout of 40%. To reach this goal, AACT invested heavily in creating a voter database with advanced technology allowing the organization to track voters, produce reports and assess progress on a real time basis. It identified, assessed and inventoried for eventual use various voter outreach methods, such as canvassing, phone banking, direct mail and email, text messaging and social media. And it developed a strategy for arranging scheduled presentations, media events and assuring that AACT maintained a strong presence in the region with recurrent voter outreach events and distribution of materials

MEDIA AND MARKETING

Media and marketing along with the Public Service Announcements were central to building brand name, recognition and credibility. The materials focused on:

- building awareness of AACT's work and impact;
- conveying understanding of relationships between voting and policy issues that directly affected citizen's daily lives;

- forging partnerships with key partner organizations, hospitals, businesses, employers, schools, universities, and financial institutions, and with maintaining produce existing relationships with citizens and policymakers(See APPENDIX B)
- weaving the network... nurturing relationships with prospective “supporters” within relevant local organizations such as the Lions Club, Chambers of Commerce, Rotaries, Faith-based groups, hospitals, businesses, and so on.

PUBLIC SERVICE ANNOUNCEMENTS

AACT worked Rio Bravo Productions to produce a 60-second commercial to launch the AACT campaign. The PSA highlighted the message, noted above, that 6 out of 10 people vote in Texas yet only 2 out of 10 people do it in the Rio Grande Valley. This aimed to raise awareness about the importance of voting and how it could effect change.

The PSA campaign was vitally important because the AACT was blessed with in-kind air time contributions from media partners across the region and from national networks that were worth around \$1.7 million during the lead-up to the 2012 general election. The PSAs catapulted AACT to high visibility and name recognition with both adults and youth, so much so that it became inundated with office calls and volunteers during all of 2012.

Like the PowerPoint presentation, the PSA opened doors that otherwise would not have given AACT the time of day. The quality and message of the PSA was clear, so much so that many people thought AACT was a national organization. The PSA provided AACT with the capability to reach people that were not being touched with the presentations, thousands of people that were

watching TV or listening to the radio. The PSA also was instrumental in helping AACT solicit funds and partners that committed to in-kind donations during the election.

OUTREACH AND AMBASSADORS

All the initiatives described above were important, but to have big impact, the greatest need was to design outreach programs tailored to different groups in the community, such as veterans outreach, grassroots outreach, parish outreach, civic professional and social organization outreach as well as local non-profit outreach.

Veterans Outreach was vital because it is an excellent group through which to recruit help for phone banking, canvassing, and voter registration drives. Also, using different types of literature, such as voter registration cards, and pledge cards for already-registered voters within VFW Posts, kept voting information readily accessible. The initial program with the vets was not as successful as expected, the problem we encountered was not that they were not registered but rather that they just were not voting. In order to address their turnout disparity, several veterans' only events were held and presentations addressing just their participation were discussed. The veterans in attendance were asked about why they thought their turnout was low and strategies were set in place to help. One solution that was implemented for example was to make a VFW post a voting location, this was discussed with the elections office and the location was approved. Although the turnout did not drastically improve, the fact that AACT was taking the time to address their needs made them more committed to the program; this helped us get them on board to motivate the youth.

The parish outreach program, building on a long tradition of church-assisted voter turnout efforts, with activities such as *from the pews to the polls*, was designed to create a contact list of all local clergy. AACT met with the Bishop and the meeting resulted in a collaborative agreement with individual parishes. Through them, AACT established congregational and other voter registration drives, distributed vital information, such as location of nearest polling place, and provided transportation to get people to their station. The amount of work that could have potentially been done however was a lot less than what was accomplished with the parishes. One of the major challenges that AACT faced with the parish program was that parishes did not feel comfortable with the collection of information because members that were undocumented were fearful they may get in trouble or go to jail. It was a hard sell to the parishes to say that the information collected would not be used for anything other than voter engagement. Building trust will take time and although the number of parish participants is not as high as AACT would like persistence is key and the fact that AACT will be working year round will help in making the parish outreach program stronger.

Grassroots movement activities were a lot sporadic and consisted of making contact lists of all key people who could help at city functions, parades, fairs, BBQ's, etc. and help gather people for local awareness meetings, registration drives and canvassing specific neighborhoods. Civic and professional/social organization outreach produced the greatest number of volunteers. They helped with turnout activities, including public presentations and events, such as monthly luncheons, to motivate people to help with AACT activities and get them to vote.

Within these different outreach groups were AACT Ambassadors, the organization's "unpaid army," who served as liaison between AACT and the groups, trained group members on the importance of voter registration, voter awareness, and how to set up and present the AACT mission statement in business settings. They themselves also participated in voter registration drives, canvassing, phone banking and other activities.

One effective part of the AACT ambassador program was the fact that within each entity was an empowered AACT messenger. AACT ambassadors were the block captains of our participating organizations. Many times, it was the AACT ambassador contact that would receive the accountability report of the organization during early vote. The fact that the ambassador would be able to disseminate the information regarding the organizations participation was crucial in spreading the message and sounding the internal alarms. The AACT ambassador program was the working model used to multiply and spread the AACT message to the entire community. As with everything, lessons to improve this program were learned. It was clear that maintaining constant contact and providing the ambassador with up to date information was key to their effectiveness. Also, it was important to set up a reward system and awards ceremony to thank the dedicated group.

YOUTH OUTREACH

It was clear to all involved with the AACT that to have immediate as well as longer-term impact on civic engagement there was need for an aggressive youth registration and follow-through effort. It seemed vitally important to teach young minds the importance of voting and, through their families and social networks, to widen voter awareness within their communities.

A compelling place to try to make contact with an important segment of the youth population was at high schools where graduating seniors 18 or 19 years of age were at or approaching the threshold of voter eligibility. To reach these seniors, AACT's first action was to seek permission from district Superintendents to visit their schools. This process began with an AACT presentation at a meeting arranged by the Region One Education Service Center, one of 20 centers created by the Texas Legislature to help districts improve academic performance and efficiency, and to implement legislative initiatives.

Initially, Superintendents did not show interest. To some extent, this was because AACT was completely unknown to them, and because they had no previous experience with GOTV campaigns inside schools. To address this at the meeting, AACT staff explained that the program was non-partisan, that its purpose was to teach youth about and engage them in the democratic process, and played the Public Service Announcement mentioned above. The explanation and the PSA eroded resistance somewhat, but the key that blew school doors wide open was presentation of a comparison between the school budgets of South Texas and other regions. Although already aware of the budgetary gap, AACT's message that the disparity might narrow more quickly if decision makers in Austin, the state capital, were forced by the ballot box to pay more attention to South Texas voters, was compelling in most Superintendent eyes. All but five of the region's 49 high schools elected to participate in the AACT youth project.

SENIOR SUMMIT AND SCHOOL PRESENTATIONS

The project's centerpiece was a high school Summit in Hidalgo County open to all seniors at the participating schools. It was a landmark event...the first-ever region-wide conference

focused on civic engagement and electoral participation for high school seniors. About 5000 students attended the one-day event. It was a kind of GOTV celebration where youth, in addition to being registered to vote by AACT staff and volunteers, they were educated on the importance of government, civic participation, the electoral process and the impact that voting could have on their future and that of their communities. Speakers and facilitators included national, state, county and city officials, each of whom stressed the importance of casting a vote. At the same time, to make the Summit enjoyable, AACT arranged entertainment through videos, music, cheerleaders and a local mariachi band. At the end of the day, AACT issued a challenge for schools to compete in producing highest voter turnout in the upcoming Primary and General elections of 2012.

Afterward, AACT reached out to schools, mainly in Starr and Cameron County, unable to send students to the Summit. Here AACT scheduled and made presentations at each school, at which time staff and volunteers also registered seniors. Also, some schools with seniors at the Summit invited AACT to make the same presentation for the benefit of students unable to be at the Summit and, at the same time, to register them to vote.

Further, during both the Primary and the General election, registered seniors received two rounds of phone calls, text messages and emails reminding them of the date, location and time for early voting and for Election Day. AACT provided participating schools with its Public Service Announcement that were played on school video channels, and with access to Voter Look Up, an online application designed specifically to provide students with information regarding their polling sites and times. So, in all, AACT registered 4435 seniors in 44 high

schools of Hidalgo, Cameron and Starr County before the 2012 Primary and General elections. Most of them attended the Summit. Some attended the Summit and subsequently participated in the AACT's individual school presentations others benefitted only from the presentations.

Lessons learned in the course of this field experiment were many. A debrief with the AACT staff brought to light several suggestions to make the next event more successful. For example, the staff agreed that registration process for the students would have to be streamlined and a process to check their registration onsite would have to be developed. There was agreement that social media would have to play a bigger part in the presentation and that the website would have to have built in capabilities for students to participate by using their mobiles. It was agreed that the presentation by the elections administrator would have to be modified in order to allow the students to feel that they had a more hands on approach to their registration. The collection of registration cards would have to be modified, and there would need to be more volunteers assigned to individual schools to avoid confusion.

Eventually, the elections of 2012 came and went. A basic question that presented itself was: Did the AACT effort make any difference in voter turnout compared to what might have happened without the effort? In an ideal research world, the convincing way to answer this question is to set up an experiment where registered seniors are randomly assigned to separate groups before an election. One or more groups would receive AACT program treatments (i.e., Summit, Summit plus Presentation and Presentation), while another, control group would get no treatment.

But the AACT was not established as a research project to test a voter turnout hypothesis. Still, the fact that not all schools participated in the AACT program still provides scope for an assessment, albeit less-than-ideal, of treatment effects. This is the subject of the next Chapter.

CHAPTER 4

METHODOLOGY

The decision by administrators of the five high schools in one county not to participate in the Summit and other AACT activities presented the possibility of a "natural" experiment where outcomes for students in schools that participated could be compared quasi-experimentally with outcomes for students in the five schools that did not participate. All students in the three counties were subject to influence by election-related radio and television advertisements, billboards and the like. Only students in participating schools received one of the three direct AACT "treatments" described earlier, i.e., Senior Summit, school presentation, and both Summit and presentation. Implicitly, there was also an assumed fourth, indirect treatment for students in participating schools who did not attend the Summit or presentation but who may have heard about them from those who did.

DATA

Data for analyzing effect were compiled over a period of 18 months. The primary database contained information on each of the 4,435 individual students who participated in AACT activities. Part of the database came from voter registration forms and pledge cards that included name of high school, age, gender, ethnicity and contact address. Two weeks prior to the 2012 Primary and General polls, AACT staff and volunteers contacted each student to remind them of the upcoming election.

Students from the 45 high schools that participated in the summit were brought to the event based on the transportation availability. In 16 of the 45 schools, entire senior classes were bused in while other schools brought all students who had a free class period during their daily school schedule. This procedure, however imperfect it may have been, assured no or very limited self-selection for summit attendance (though self-selection would still affect the decision to register during the summit). Once at the summit every student was given a voter registration card as well as a pledge card, there was a presentation on properly filling out the information and on their way out the cards were collected. Although there were close to 5,000 students in attendance for the event less than 2,000 cards were collected that day.

The data collected can be broken down into three sections: AACT participants, non-participants and indirect influence participants. The data set and characteristics are illustrated in Table 4.1 with a breakdown, if applicable, by county, treatment received, gender and ethnicity/race. The breakdown shows that a majority of the AACT participants were from Hidalgo County. The treatment with the most participants was the Summit with 1854 students; the Summit participants also had the highest voter participation rates in both the Primary and General election. The gender breakdown highlights that there were 553 more female participants than males and the ethnicity data reveals that 90% of all AACT participants were Hispanic. Non-Participant data was limited and there was again an increase in the number of females. Indirect participants include most all students who attended the summit and or presentation but that opted to register to vote on their own. Indirect participant turnout was considerably lower than the participation rates of AACT students who received one of the treatments; there were also more females than males in this group.

Table 4.1. Data Breakdown: AACT Treatment, Non-Participants and Indirect Participants

	Totals	Primary		General	
AACT Direct Treatment		#	%	#	%
County					
Hidalgo	3176	170	5.4%	1095	34.5%
Starr	338	34	10.1%	79	23.4%
Cameron	921	49	5.3%	238	25.8%
Total	4435	253	5.7%	1415	31.9%
Treatment (i.e., summit, summit and presentation, presentation only)					
Summit	1854	136	7.7%	625	34.0%
Summit and Presentation	1273	92	7.4%	351	27.8%
Presentation Only	1308	25	1.9%	439	33.8%
Total	4435	253	5.7%	1415	31.9%
Gender					
Male	1941	94	4.8%	528	27.2%
Female	2494	159	6.4%	887	35.6%
Total	4435	253	5.7%	1415	31.9%
Ethnicity/Race					
Hispanic	3893	219	5.6%	1223	31.4%
White (non-Hisp)	466	29	6.2%	172	36.9%
Black	43	2	4.7%	14	32.6%
Other	33	3	9.1%	6	18.2%
Non-Participants (Cameron County)					
Gender					
Male	259	16	6.1%	58	22.3%
Female	365	24	6.7%	61	16.7%
Total	624	40	6.4%	119	19.0%
Indirect Participants					
County					
Hidalgo	9925	34	.03%	1158	11.7%
Starr	1278	186	14.6%	266	20.8%
Cameron	6075	239	3.9%	656	10.8%
Gender					
Male	8114	176	2.1%	922	11.3%
Female	9164	283	3.0%	1158	12.6%
Total	17278	459	2.7%	2080	12.0%
*Indirect participant information varied based on the county voter file					

After the 2012 Primary, another part of the database came from 450,000 voter registration files supplied by the three counties indicating the voting history of each individual and, separately, from records of everyone who voted in the Primary. All Primary voters aged 18 or 19 were extracted from these records and merged with data from the registration files. The same process was repeated after the General election, producing a database of 21,713 18/19 year olds in the three counties who were eligible to vote, including the 4,435 AACT treatment participants. Finally, based on association of non-participant home address with school district boundaries, every individual in the database was associated with a specific high school in the three-county region. This procedure may have inadvertently ascribed some dropouts to high schools. However, because it seems unlikely that there would be many registered dropouts, the effect of this inaccuracy on analysis should be small.

Thus, in the end, the database contained the 2012 voting records for all 18 and 19 year old registered seniors in the region, the name of their school, whether they participated in AACT activities and, for these participants, their age, gender and ethnicity. These records are the principal data that the present research uses to assess the extent to which each of the direct and indirect treatments, if any, influenced the decision of seniors to vote.

ANALYSIS

Voter turnout for the Tri-County region as a whole and separately for each county are shown in Table 4.2. A first observation is that, as is typical, the number of people voting the General was substantially greater than the number in the Primary election: 4338 versus 721 for the

region. The regional ratio of General to Primary voters was 6.1, ranging from a low of 1.6 in Starr to 11 in Hidalgo, with 6.2 in Cameron.

Except in Starr, primary turnout rates were multiples greater for AACT program participants than for other voters. Overall, at 5.7% for participants and 2.7 % for non-participants, turnout was 111% higher. This amalgamated figure, however, was driven by Hidalgo, where turnout was 1700% greater. It was also greater in Cameron, 36%, but substantially less in Starr, where turnout was 31% lower among participants. So the AACT program effect for the Primary election was not consistent across counties. This was not the case for the General election, where turnout in every county was greater, sometimes substantially greater for participants compared to non-participants: 195% in Hidalgo, 13% in Starr and 139% in Cameron, and 95% for the whole.

Of note in both elections is that outcomes in Hidalgo were much more pronounced than in the other counties. In part, this may stem from the fact that AACT's base was there, as were AACT's community organization partners and most of its outreach activities. Further, because participating high schools in Hidalgo were closer to AACT's base, greater shares of their students attended the Summit, and proximity allowed AACT to do more frequent follow up visits. Additionally, the Hidalgo County Elections Administrator was an AACT board member and facilitated work with the elections office in Hidalgo County. This allowed for better coordination of school visits and voting machine training than in the other counties. In a sense, Hidalgo benefitted from the full weight of AACT operations while Starr and Cameron got a kind of AACT-lite. And so given that its voter population was almost double that of the other counties, it was mainly Hidalgo's weight in the total that drove regional averages.

Table 4.2. Voter Turnout for 2012 Primary and General Elections Among AACT Participants and Non-Participants in South Texas

		Voted	Total	% Voted	Difference in Participation AACT vs. Non-AACT
Tri-County	Primary Election				
	Did not participate	459	17,278	2.7%	111%
	Participated	253	4,435	5.7%	
	Total	712	21,713	3.3%	
	General Election				
	Did not participate	2,923	17,278	16.9%	95%
	Participated	1,415	4,435	31.9%	
	Total	4,338	21,713	20.0%	
Hidalgo County	Primary				
	Did not participate	34	9,925	0.3%	1700%
	Participated	170	3,176	5.4%	
	Total	204	13,101	1.6%	
	General Election				
	Did not participate	1,158	9,925	11.7%	195%
	Participated	1,096	3,176	34.5%	
	Total	2,254	13,101	17.2%	
Starr County	Primary				
	Did not participate	186	1,278	14.6%	-31%
	Participated	34	338	10.1%	
	Total	220	1,616	13.6%	
	General Election				
	Did not participate	266	1,278	20.8%	13%
	Participated	79	338	23.4%	
	Total	345	1,616	21.3%	
Cameron County	Primary				
	Did not participate	239	6,075	3.9%	36%
	Participated	49	921	5.3%	
	Total	288	6,996	4.1%	
	General Election				
	Did not participate	656	6,075	10.8%	139%
	Participated	238	921	25.8%	
	Total	894	6,996	12.8%	

At the same time, the large difference between Primary and General turnout in all counties may be related, in part, to changes in AACT operations between the two elections. Going into the General election the public service announcement campaign was able to use \$1.7 million in in-kind contributions of air time. The AACT website had been re-vamped, and the voter look-up application was updated and advertised, and used at election offices throughout the region. Also, AACT staff and volunteers were better prepared during early General voting while school visits and polling locations were coordinated to better meet the needs of the students. Also, each school received a daily update on turnout rates for their students, and district Superintendents worked more closely with the AACT initiative, several of them sending out press releases as well as campus wide notices informing staff and teachers about election dates and times.

It is important to note that the vast majority of the 17,728 non-participants were at the same schools as AACT program participants. One plausible result of this amalgam, pulling in the direction of narrowing turnout differences between participants and others, is that non-participants were subject to indirect influence from talking with participating schoolmates. So differences in turnout between participants and others shown in Table 4.2 might be narrower than what could have been the case had the two student groups been isolated from each other. At the same time, pulling in the opposite direction, i.e., to increase turnout differences between participants and others, is the effect of self-selection. It is possible, indeed likely that seniors pre-disposed to being receptive to AACT's campaign (i.e., to be interested in voting), were a disproportionate share of all participants in the participating schools, possibly also a disproportionate share of Summit attendees. If this was the case, then disinterested seniors would be disproportionately represented among non-participants and exaggerate turnout differences. At

the limit, with this reasoning it is possible to speculate that all or most of the observed differences in outcome stem from self-selection. However, without a sense of which directional effect was dominant, it is hard to tell whether turnout differences shown in Table 4.2 overestimate or underestimate AACT program effects.

Fortunately, to shed a bit of light on this issue, the database contains records of a modest number of registered seniors who enrolled in the five Cameron County schools that did not participate in AACT activities. Compared to the Tri-County non-participant Primary average of 2.7%, their turnout rate, 6.4%, was considerably higher. Likewise, for the General election, the average rate of 22.4% for the five schools was much higher than the 16.9% for non-participants in the other schools. The same seems to apply in relation to the Cameron County averages of 3.9% and 10.8%. Of course, there was wide variation among the five schools, but because the numbers that voted in each school are quite small, the 5-school averages, 6.4% and 22.4%, seem more indicative of what turnout might have been without AACT indirect influence. Using this comparative standard, the data suggest that AACT may indeed have made an important difference in outcomes, but not as large as implied by the differences shown in Table 4.2.

But did these differences favor all seniors in the same way? Or just certain groups? To cast light on this, Table 4.3 presents voter turnout rates of AACT program participants, distinguished by ethnicity and race. The Table suggests that AACT activities had positive if varying effects across the board. The Primary rate was higher for White students in Cameron, higher for Hispanics elsewhere. In the General election, turnout was somewhat higher for White students everywhere, as was the rise in turnout between elections in Hidalgo and Starr. In terms of

political impact in the region, however, the much greater weight of Hispanic students in the total, to the extent that students in general could influence election outcomes, hinted that they might have a more important influence than did others on politics and policy in the region.

Table 4.3. Voter Turnout for 2012 Elections in South Texas, by Ethnicity and Race

	Ethnicity / Race	Total Voters	Voted in Primary	Voted in General
Hidalgo	Hispanic	2793	5.4%	34.0%
	White (non-Hisp)	322	4.7%	39.1%
	Black	32	3.1%	37.5%
	Other	29	11.1%	22.2%
	Total	3176	5.4%	34.5%
Starr	Hispanic	307	10.4%	22.8%
	White (non-Hisp)	29	6.9%	31.0%
	Black	2	0.0%	0.0%
	Other	0	0.0%	0.0%
	Total	338	10.1%	23.4%
Cameron	Hispanic	793	4.6%	25.3%
	White (non-Hisp)	115	10.4%	32.2%
	Black	9	11.1%	22.2%
	Other	4	0.0%	0.0%
	Total	921	5.3%	12.8%

Unfortunately, there are no state or national statistics at hand that reveal voter turnout rates specifically for 18/19 year olds. Although it is clear that South Texas AACT participants performed much better than non-participants in the General election of 2012, there is no direct way to assess the extent to which the rates achieved by program participants are comparable to Texas or US averages. However, 2012 national averages for 18-24 year-olds, shown in Table 4.5

suggest that South Texas outcomes may have been quite good for Hispanics. For them, the 34.5% rate for 18/19 years olds in Hidalgo compares favorably with the 34% national average for 18-24 year-olds... because one may assume with some confidence that turnout among the youngest in that age bracket, dominated by graduating high school seniors, would have much lower turnout than the 34% group average.

Table 4.5. Voter Turnout for 2012 General Election in the US, by Age Group and Race/Ethnicity.

	% Voting		
	All	18-24	25-44
All	62%	41%	57%
White, non-Hisp	64%	42%	59%
Black	66%	49%	65%
Hispanic	48%	34%	47%
Asian	47%	31%	47%

Source: Data from Clement and Sullivan, 2013.

It seems clear that AACT participants did better overall than non-participants, but the foregoing examination does not disentangle the various factors, such as type of AACT direct or indirect treatment, high school attributes, gender and age, that might have interacted in different ways to yield higher or lower turnout rates.

Suspicion that AACT treatments might not have had equivalent impact stems from juxtaposition of General turnout rates shown in Table 4.1 for each of the counties (i.e., 34.5% in Hidalgo, 23.4% in Starr and 25.5% in Cameron), with the distribution of participants among the three direct AACT activities across the counties, shown in Table 4.5. Although an impression, the juxtaposition of turnout rates on the distribution of participants across treatments suggests

that the Summit may have had greatest impact... explaining why turnout was so much higher in Hidalgo, followed by Summit and Presentation and Presentation alone.

Table 4.6 Distribution of AACT Participants by Treatment and County

	Summit	Summit and Presentation	Presentation	Total
Hidalgo County	49%	22.5%	28.5%	100%
Starr County	0%	92.0%	8.0%	100%
Cameron County	27%	26.0%	47.0%	100%

A Probit regression model presented in Table 4.7, explores this further while also assessing effects of other factors.

Table 4.7. Tri-County Probit Regression Model of Likelihood of Voter Turnout

	Variable	Marginal Effects	Robust Standard Errors
Primary Election	Treatment: Summit	0.0034	(0.00569)
	Treatment: Summit and Presentation	0.0076	(0.00675)
	Treatment: Presentation	-0.0144*	(0.00320)
	Indirect Influence	-0.0361*	(0.00805)
	Gender: Male	-0.0154*	(0.00201)
	Birth Year 1994	-0.0124*	(0.00201)
	Observations (N)	21,121	
General Election	Treatment: Summit	0.1094*	(0.02344)
	Treatment: Summit and Presentation	0.0352**	(0.21753)
	Treatment: Presentation	0.0493*	(0.02208)
	Indirect Influence	-0.0677*	(0.01904)
	Gender: Male	-0.0383*	(0.00538)
	Birth Year 1994	0.1088*	(0.00547)
	Observations (N)	21,522	
	* p<0.05		
	**p<0.10		

Here the regression model for the Primary election evaluates the impact that AACT's specific treatments had on voting. Participants who attended the Summit and the Summit and Presentation did not have any significant increase in voting compared to non-participants. Participants who received just the presentation were 1.4% less likely to vote than the non-participants. In general, the model also suggests that males were slightly less likely to vote than females.

Relative to the Primary election model, the General election regression revealed a considerably higher percentage difference. Summit participants were now 10.9% more likely to vote than registered voters in a non-participating school. Summit participants who also attended a Presentation were 3.5% more likely to vote. And unlike in the Primary model, participants who only attended a Presentation were 4.9% more likely to vote. Further, non-participating students in participating schools who were subject to indirect influence by schoolmates were 6.7% less likely to vote. As before, males were less likely to vote than females.

The probit regression on table 4.8 provides only Cameron County information. Cameron County is used to here to highlight the difference between participating and non-participating schools because all non-participating schools were in this county. Thus, Cameron County is the only true comparison of the effects AACT treatments had. As mentioned earlier, schools that opted to participate bussed their students to the Summit, in the case of Cameron County about 50% of the students were unable to attend due to transportation and as a result there were more school presentations. Non-Participating schools did not give a reason for their lack of participation and perhaps had a program for their students already.

Table 4.8. Cameron County Probit Regression Model of Likelihood of Voter Turnout

	Variable	Marginal Effects	Robust Standard Errors
Primary Election	Treatment: Summit	0.0029	(0.00828)
	Treatment: Summit and Presentation	0.0189	(0.01410)
	Treatment: Presentation	-0.0110*	(0.00481)
	Indirect Influence	-0.0212*	(0.00711)
	Gender: Male	-0.0566*	(0.00407)
	Birth Year 1994	-0.0282*	(0.00358)
	Observations (N)	921	
General Election	Treatment: Summit	0.1009*	(0.03803)
	Treatment: Summit and Presentation	0.0062*	(0.03608)
	Treatment: Presentation	0.0452*	(0.03106)
	Indirect Influence	0.0300*	(0.01949)
	Gender: Male	-0.0513*	(0.01041)
	Birth Year 1994	-0.0482*	(0.01055)
	Observations (N)	921	

* p<0.05

**p<0.10

The Cameron County regression model results show that participants during the Primary election who attended the Summit and the Summit and Presentation did not have any significant increase in voting compared to non-participants. Participants who received just the presentation were 1.1% less likely to vote than the non-participants. Males were 5.6% less likely to vote than females and those born in 1994 were 2.8% less likely to vote.

The General election regression revealed a considerably higher percentage difference than that of the Primary. Summit participants were 10% more likely to vote than registered voters in non-participating schools. Summit participants who also attended a Presentation did not any

significant difference. And unlike in the Primary model, participants who only attended a Presentation were 4.5% more likely to vote. Non-participating students in participating schools who were subject to indirect influence by schoolmates were 3% more likely to vote. As before, males were less likely to vote than females and those born in 1994 were 4.8% less likely to vote.

Overall, the forgoing analysis indicates that AACT treatments were influential in raising turnout, with the Summit, combined or not combined with a Presentation, having effects only during the General election. In the Primary, we observed that some treatment resulted in negative results and in both cases the indirect participants had negative outcome.

CHAPTER 5

DISCUSSION

CONCLUSIONS

The motivation behind the research project presented here was to identify ways to increase voter turnout among youth, especially that of Hispanic youth in lower income areas that historically have exhibited low turnout in general and, from this, limited ability to engage in politics and the policy process. My personal interest aside, the extra focus on Hispanic youth stems, in part, from the observation that these young people are today the most educated members of their communities and thus, in principle, are in good position to serve as vanguard for greater participation of Hispanic citizens in the democratic process.

Directly related to this perspective, another reason for the focus is that the available research literature provides only limited guidance on effective ways to raise turnout in this population. Youth, Hispanic or no, are generally defined as those who are 18 to 24 years of age, treated more or less as a singular age category (i.e., 18 year olds are the same as 24 year olds). Studies of them rely mainly on data concerning college students. These data are inadequate for understanding response among sub-groups, such as high school seniors at the threshold of voter eligibility. This particular inadequacy resonates for researchers and political activists who believe, as I do, that the most promising under-studied way increase political participation of Hispanic and other youth is to reach out to them at the moment they advance toward and move across the voter

eligibility threshold. Educating and encouraging them to vote while they are still in high school presents itself as one obvious and promising way to do that.

This research project, limited as it is to one region (South Texas), to one moment in political time (2012), and by a quasi-experimental design, suggests that the approach, if done with an appropriate mix of treatments in an appropriate organizational setting, can be effective, significantly so, in raising turnout.

It is uncertain whether an organization such as the AACT, or its varied activities, can be easily replicated in other places and at other times. But for any organization, the finding that a large-scale pre-election Summit-like event, whether called a convention, jamboree, celebration, carnival or shindig, at least when set within a GOTV campaign that at the same time engages in broad-based advertising, social and broadcast media information diffusion, auditorium presentations and other traditional activities, can be an effective turnout instrument for youth. This may be because high school and other youth tend to be more enthused by mass celebrations than older people. But this is speculation. There may be robust social-behavioral theories to explain why Summit-like events exert influence, but such theories have thus far proven elusive.

In any event, the implication of my research findings for political practice is that, on the margin, it can be worthwhile for organizations that sponsor or implement GOTV and similar campaigns to focus on about-to-be voters. The data presented here cannot show it, but there is a strong sense that the earlier an individual starts to vote, the more likely that he or she will continue to vote regularly as they grow older.

One of the main implications for the community engaged in voter turnout research is that treating youth between the ages of 18 and 24 as if they are of a single age may mislead. Seniors in high school are in most respects not the same with respect to political participation as 22 year-olds completing college or in the labor force, or 24 year-olds in graduate study. Each of these groups is a worthwhile target of research... at least until research shows that they can be regarded as a single age without loss of analytical coherence.

A further implication is that the research community might benefit from broader exploration of the range of different treatment interventions now being implemented to raise voter turnout. The literature has explored effectiveness of what might be called "traditional" treatments for youth and/or general populations, such as television and radio advertisements, door to door canvassing, phone banking and direct mail campaigns via the internet and various social media, and so on. This list of mechanisms, though it includes most of the range of what is being done and does embrace newer ideas as they emerge, such as Tweet campaigns, do not exhaust the array of existing mass or smaller scale approaches, some of which, the Summit for example, are becoming more common, especially in youth turnout exercises.

Finally, it seems appropriate to underscore that although engaging youth in the democratic political process is a major challenge – not least because they have other pressing priorities, they are not immune to treatment. As this research project illustrates, even high school seniors, likely among the least interested of youth, can be motivated to vote in significant numbers through non-partisan education, engagement and empowerment interventions that enable them, afterward, to promote the interests of their communities.

The lessons learned throughout this experiment should also be noted because they add to the pool of knowledge gathered about effective youth voter outreach. The 2012 AACT High School Senior Summit could not have happened without the cooperation and collaboration of school districts at a county wide level. It was the support of the Superintendents that made this idea a possibility. The moment the program was presented to a room filled of educators that understood the funding implication was the moment the program was a reality. Once we had the permission of the school districts to proceed getting the teachers on board was easy. It may be cliché to say teachers have the power to change a student's life but in this case it was true. Every teacher that participated and collaborated with AACT went above and beyond their duty to teach. These educators made extra time to attend the summit and let AACT present in their classroom. These same teachers followed-up with their students and passed out information during election time. Had it not been for their commitment to follow up the results may have been different.

Another very important partnership was the elections office; they provided the staff and training to the students and were on hand to answer any questions. In addition, their work with individual schools made it possible for students to host mock elections and get familiar with the voting machines. Along with the collaboration of the county there were also collaborations at the state and national level. VotoLatino as well as NCLR provided students with national perspectives as well as gave them printed information regarding the importance of civic participation.

An event of this magnitude had never been done, certainly not one with over 5,000 high school seniors. In retrospect, having more volunteers and security attend would have been a good

idea. Also, we all agreed that having an MC would have helped in moving the program along as well as helped in keeping the program exciting. Another important lesson was that events like this shouldn't be held during football season and opposing schools should not be seated next to each other. Keeping the students engaged was difficult, we found student were most receptive when their classmates were on stage talking to them.

This research was not without limitations, and there were three fundamental weaknesses. First, was the fact that this was not a randomized assignment and therefore it was impossible to control for self-selection. Second, the information and data gathered did not include individual school rolls and as a result there is no way of knowing what share of students may have been drop-outs or college. Last, for the schools that received the presentation there was no way of showing presentation variation equality.

Overall, the most valuable lesson learned was that a youth outreach effort cannot be coordinated without the help of the community. Human capital in the forms of parents, teachers, colleges, hospitals, businesses, cities, non-profits, radio, television, print media etc...all these people worked together to send a message to our youth-- that they are the future, and that their vote will make a difference.

APPENDIX A

AACT LOGO



APPENDIX B

MEDIA AND COMMUNITY PARTNERS

ENTORNO

PERSONALIDAD...CREADORES...HISTORIA DE ÉXITO

¡VOTA, EJERCE TU DERECHO!

El voto es un derecho y un privilegio con el cual nacemos todos los hombres y mujeres de los Estados Unidos. Votar es ejercer nuestro derecho como ciudadanos libres de elegir a nuestro gobierno y de participar en la democracia. Sin votación, no hay democracia. La democracia es al final del día, lo que forja a las grandes naciones. Votar nos da la oportunidad de hacernos escuchar y expresar nuestras opiniones, sugerencias e inconformidades. Así que la próxima vez que seas conmovido a ejercer tu derecho al voto en cualquier periodo electoral, reflexiona sobre el futuro, así como en la forma en la que quieres contribuir con tu país.

AACT NOW
El Centro de Alianza de Texas (AACT) es una organización no lucrativa creada para unir a organizaciones comunitarias, hospitales, empresas, escuelas, universidades e instituciones financieras, y diversos asociaciones estatales y nacionales para incrementar el porcentaje de votantes en el sur de Texas.

La misión de AACT es crear, con la participación de la ciudadanía y la comunidad entera una estructura en el sur de Texas, para informar y educar a la comunidad sobre la importancia de su voto en el proceso electoral.

**¡NUESTRO VOTO ES NUESTRA VOZ
Y NO LO PODEMOS
DEJAR PASAR POR ALTO!**

612 Nolana Ave, suite 430, McAllen, Texas 78504
Tel: (956) 664-AACT Fax: (956) 664-2231
LLAME GRATIS AL: 1-855-411-AACT
info@aaactnow.org www.aaactnow.org

TO WHOM IT MAY CONCERN:

Over the past year, a group of concerned leaders from the South Texas Community have come together to form the Advocacy Alliance Center of Texas (AACT). The Advocacy Alliance Center of Texas (AACT) is a non-profit, non-partisan organization that was established to unite community organizations, hospitals, businesses, large employers, schools, universities and financial institutions as well as various state and national partnerships to cultivate voter engagement and increase voter turnout in South Texas.

For more than 50 years South Texas has been well below the state voter turnout average. Reaching the Rio

Grande Valley in a meaningful way has proven to be a difficult task to many in state and out of state organizations. The formation of AACT and the non-partisan nature of the work will allow our organization to effectively send out a message that we are grass roots and our efforts will stay here in our community.

AACT is committed to a year round effort to educate, engage and empower the citizens of South Texas. Our methods and material will be inclusive and our collaborations throughout the community will reinforce the importance partnerships make in this type of "Get Out The Vote" effort.

Additional Partners:

- Voto Latino
- NCLR
- Texas Civic Engagement Table
- Texas Migrant Council
- Equal Voice Network
- Abriendo Puertas Parental Communication Initiative, Inc.
- Advocacy Resource Center for Housing (ARCH)

- Affordable Homes of South Texas, Inc.
- AVANCE, Inc. – Rio Grande Valley
- Boys & Girls Club of McAllen
- Boys & Girls Club of Pharr
- Community Council of the Rio Grande Valley
- Easter Seals, Rio Grande Valley
- Edinburg Child Care, Inc.
- Holy Family Services Birth Center
- Community Hope Projects, Inc.
- McAllen Literacy Center, Inc.
- One Hand – Una Mano, Inc.
- Pharr Literacy Project, Inc.
- Rio Grande Valley Diabetes Association
- Rio Grande Valley Empowerment Zone Association
- Ronald McDonald House Charities of the Rio Grande Valley
- South TX Empowerment of Women's Center
- South Texas Literacy Coalition
- Southwest Community Investment Corporation
- Starr County Industrial Foundation
- VAMOS
- Valley Initiative for Development and Advancement (VIDA)
- Boys & Girls Club of Edinburg
- Christian Life Church
- Colonias Unidas
- Lakeway Ministries – A Family Church, Inc.
- Love Thy Neighbor Service Organization
- Palmer Drug Abuse Program
- Planned Parenthood of Hidalgo County, TX, Inc.
- Proyecto Azteca
- Proyecto de Desarrollo Humano

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